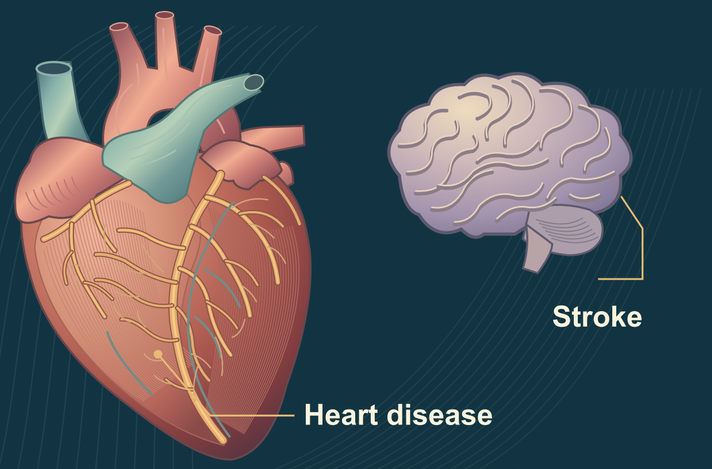
Physical function around a cardiovascular event

Across three cohorts, people who later reported heart disease or stroke already had more difficulty with everyday tasks.

01 — THE INDEX EVENT



Participants reported a physician's diagnosis at follow-up.

02 — THE STUDY POPULATION

23,307

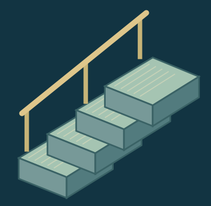
adults aged 50+ without CVD at baseline

England	ELSA	**5,285**
United States	HRS	**10,233**
China	CHARLS	**7,789**

4,355 reported incident CVD

18,952 remained event-free during follow-up.

03 — WHAT PEOPLE REPORTED



Mobility

7 questions · 0–100 points

e.g., difficulty climbing stairs



Daily function

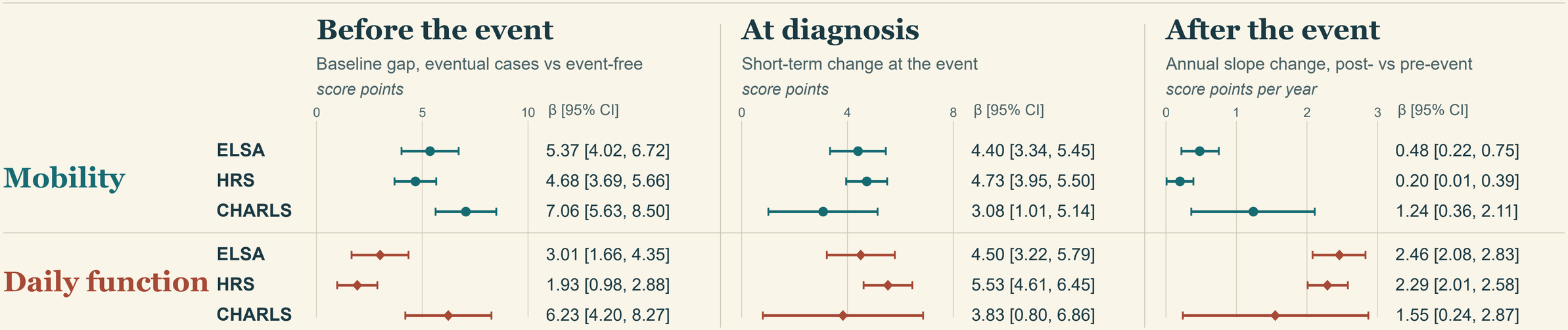
5 ADL + 5 IADL items · 0–200 points

e.g., dressing or shopping for groceries

On both scales, a higher score means greater difficulty.

A gap before diagnosis, a step at the event, and a steeper slope after

Cohort-specific adjusted estimates. Symbols mark the estimate; bars span its 95% confidence interval.



Before diagnosis Baseline levels already differed. Pre-event mobility slopes showed no clear difference in any cohort.

After diagnosis Both scores rose at the event. In all three cohorts, their annual increases were steeper afterward.

Observational study • Illustrations are schematic • Source: Zhou et al., BMC Public Health 26, 2184 (2026), Tables 1–3 and S1.

doi:10.1186/s12889-026-27763-w